

Answer Keys, Band Criteria & Next Steps

Everything you need to score the Diagnostic (Class 1) and Practice Test 1 (Class 8): every answer with the passage sentence or script line that proves it, accepted spelling and number variants, approximate raw-score-to-band conversion tables, the four Writing and four Speaking criteria in plain language, a band-estimation worksheet, and guidance on giving results back kindly and turning mistakes into a study plan.

Diagnostic /10 + /13 + W & S estimates

Practice Test 1 /40 + /40

Bands 5–8 described

Teacher copy

SCORING PRINCIPLES (SCORE THE IELTS WAY, AND EXPLAIN WHY)

Mark **strictly**, as the real test does, because a kind mark now becomes an unpleasant surprise on test day. **One mark per question**; no half marks. An answer earns the mark only if it is **spelled correctly**, is **within the word limit**, and has the right **singular or plural** form (Lesson 2.1). Words from the question that are already printed (a "\$" sign, "square meters") are not needed. **Numbers** may be written as digits or words (*25* or *twenty-five*).

Capital letters don't matter. **American and British spellings are both accepted** (*neighbor / neighbour, centers / centres*): these papers and the online lessons both use American English, and the test accepts either. For "choose TWO" questions, each correct letter earns one mark, in either order. In the True/False/Not Given and Yes/No/Not Given items, the answer must use the right set of words: **TRUE** on a Yes/No task is marked wrong in the real test, so point this out even when you give the mark in class.

For self-marking in Class 9, tell learners: "If you're not sure whether your answer is acceptable, circle it and ask me. Don't give yourself the benefit of the doubt, and don't take it away either."

AT A GLANCE

SECTION	DIAGNOSTIC (CLASS 1)	PRACTICE TEST 1 (CLASS 8)
Listening	1 section, 10 questions · /10 → rough band (table in the diagnostic)	4 sections, 40 questions · /40 → approximate band (table below)
Academic Reading	1 passage, 13 questions · /13 → rough band	3 passages, 40 questions · /40 → approximate band
Writing	Task 2 sample, 20 min → band estimate on 4 criteria	(Writing is tested in Practice Test 2, Class 16)

SECTION	DIAGNOSTIC (CLASS 1)	PRACTICE TEST 1 (CLASS 8)
Speaking	Part 1 + short Part 2, 3 min → band estimate on 4 criteria	(Speaking is sampled in Class 16)

DIAGNOSTIC · ANSWER KEY

◆ LISTENING /10 · THE LEARNING COMMONS

Q	ANSWER	ALSO ACCEPT	SCRIPT LINE
1	midnight	12 am · 12:00 a.m. · 12 midnight · 24:00 · 00:00 (not 10, not 12 pm)	"Until last year, the building closed at ten... Since September, though, we've stayed open until midnight from Monday to Friday." Distractor: ten
2	3	three	"We used to let you book a week in advance... now you can only book up to three days ahead." Distractor: a week
3	2	two	"each group can have a room for a maximum of two hours a day"
4	second	2nd	"That was true in the old building, but the tutors are now on the second floor" Distractor: ground
5	student card	(both words needed; card alone: no mark)	"You don't need your passport or a letter from your department. Just bring your student card"
6	B		"You're welcome to bring water, as long as it's in a bottle with a lid, but no food of any kind" (A: "not just on silent"; C: "all year round, not only during exam periods")
7	B		"the problem I see most often with new students is that they don't know how to find journal articles" (printing and bookings are mentioned first as distractors)
8	B		"Last year we ran it on Monday mornings... so this year it's on Wednesday afternoons, at two o'clock"
9–10	B, D	either order; 1 mark each	"you can borrow headphones... and you can book a one-to-one meeting with a subject librarian" (A: handled by Student Services; C: "no library fines anymore"; E: not mentioned)

◆ READING /13 · "POCKET FORESTS"

Q	ANSWER	EVIDENCE IN THE PASSAGE
1	iv	A: "they are planted in a way that differs sharply from conventional tree planting" (the paragraph describes the method: density, native species, layers)

Q	ANSWER	EVIDENCE IN THE PASSAGE
2	ii	B: "Supporters claim that pocket forests grow up to ten times faster... Independent researchers are more cautious."
3	i	C: "Where pocket forests appear to perform well is in attracting wildlife." (Noise is a detail, not the main idea.)
4	vi	D: "The social side of these projects..."; residents plant together, volunteers return, a school uses the forest
5	v	E: "Critics, however, warn against seeing pocket forests as a quick fix... 'one useful tool among many'" (Heading iii is a trap: E mentions expensive soil preparation, not the price of land.)
6	FALSE	"Instead of a few widely spaced saplings, volunteers plant three or four young trees and shrubs in every square meter"
7	TRUE	"choosing only species that are native to the local area"
8	TRUE	"between a fifth and a quarter of the saplings died as the canopy closed above them"
9	FALSE	"this effect was measured at only three of the sites"
10	NOT GIVEN	D says students "measure the growth of the trees and record the birds they see"; nothing about test results
11	ten times	"grow up to ten times faster" · also accept 10 times
12	two summers	"many volunteers return to weed and water the site during the first two summers" · also accept 2 summers
13	shade	"a mature street tree provides far more shade than any newly planted sapling"

◆ WRITING SAMPLE · WHAT TO LOOK FOR

- ◆ **Question type:** opinion ("To what extent do you agree or disagree?", Lesson 3.2). A full answer states a position early and keeps it. "Partly agree" is fine if the writer says clearly *which* part and why.
- ◆ **Task Response cap:** an essay that only describes university life, or only lists subjects, without a position, is unlikely to go above 5 on this criterion.
- ◆ **Useful ideas** (any are fine): broader thinking, employability, discovering interests, social connection vs workload, cost, lower grades, loss of

◆ A MODEL RESPONSE (ABOUT BAND 7, 205 WORDS)

It is sometimes argued that universities should require every student to complete at least one course outside their own discipline. Although this would add to already heavy workloads, I largely agree with the idea, because the benefits for students are considerable.

The main advantage is that a course in an unfamiliar field trains students to think in new ways. An engineering student who studies history, for example, has to weigh conflicting sources and build an argument from incomplete evidence, a skill that is rarely practiced in technical subjects but is valuable in any professional role. Such courses can also reveal

depth. Mark the development of ideas, not whether they match this list.

- ◆ **Length:** it is a 20-minute sample, so don't penalize 180–250 words. Under about 150 words, note it: it suggests speed is an issue.
- ◆ **Estimate each criterion** with the band criteria below; record evidence on the diagnostic note grid.

unexpected interests, and some students discover a second career path this way.

Admittedly, critics point out that degree programs are already crowded, and that a compulsory extra course could lower students' grades in their main subject. This concern is reasonable, but it could be addressed by grading the outside course as pass or fail, or by letting students choose it from a broad list.

In conclusion, although the requirement needs careful design, I believe that a single course beyond one's specialism is a small investment that produces more flexible and better-informed graduates.

Original model written for this kit. Show it **after** learners have had their own estimate back, and ask them to find the position, the two topic sentences and one concession.

PRACTICE TEST 1 · LISTENING KEY /40

Q	ANSWER	ALSO ACCEPT / DON'T ACCEPT	SCRIPT LINE
Section 1 · Greenway Community Gardens (form and table completion)			
1	Ferreira	exact spelling only (FERREIRA)	"Martina Ferreira. That's F-E-double R-E-I-R-A."
2	Juniper	exact spelling only	"Flat 3, 18 Juniper Road. Juniper is J-U-N-I-P-E-R."
3	0412 559 390	with or without spaces or hyphens · not 0412 558 390	"five-five-eight, three-nine-oh. Oh, sorry, no, it's five-five-nine, three-nine-oh." Distractor: 558
4	25	twenty-five · not 50	"A full plot is fifty square meters, and a half plot is twenty-five... I'll go for the smaller one."
5	March	not February	"Most people start in February... February's difficult... Could I start in March?"
6	neighbor	neighbour · not poster	"Well, actually, my neighbor told me about the gardens last year. I only saw the poster last week." (The question says first heard.)
7	40	forty · not 60	"for a half plot it's forty... Only for people over sixty-five... so for you it's forty"
8	20	twenty · not 15	"It used to be fifteen dollars, but it went up to twenty this year."

Q	ANSWER	ALSO ACCEPT / DON'T ACCEPT	SCRIPT LINE
9	sprays	spray (singular): no mark · weedkillers / pesticides: no mark (they are examples; the gap asks for the word after "chemical")	"you mustn't use any chemical sprays: no weedkillers, no pesticides"
10	Saturday	not Sunday	"It's on the first Saturday of each month. It used to be Sundays..."

Section 2 • Marsh Lane Nature Reserve (map labelling, multiple choice)

11	B		"When you come out of the front door and face the lake, you'll see the bike racks immediately on your right" (facing north, right = east)
12	C	not A (the old position)	"the old leaflet says... on the left of the visitor center... we've moved it: the children's trail now starts halfway up the main path, on the left-hand side"
13	E		"In the corner above the east path, where the two paths meet, there's the picnic area."
14	D		"take that eastern branch and follow it right to the end, you'll reach the wildflower meadow"
15	F	not G	"it takes you all the way up to the lake. When you get there, the bird hide is on your left."
16	B		"some people think it was set up to protect a rare orchid... In fact... The reserve was created as part of a flood-control project"
17	A		"they're most active just after sunrise, so if you want to see them, you'll need to come early in the morning"
18	B		"places are limited, so you do need to book them on our website" (A: "They're free"; C: "about ninety minutes now")
19–20	C, E	either order; 1 mark each	"please don't feed the birds... please don't fly drones" (dogs "welcome on a short lead", photos: "please take as many photographs as you like", meadow "you're welcome to walk off the path")

Section 3 • Food-waste project (multiple choice, matching, note completion)

Q	ANSWER	ALSO ACCEPT / DON'T ACCEPT	SCRIPT LINE
21	B		"it wasn't her idea... it started because I worked in a restaurant kitchen for two years" (C: "Not properly yet")
22	B		"we only managed to weigh the waste on three days... we don't think the figures are representative" (A and C are ruled out: the scales "were accurate", the staff "were brilliant")
23	C		"You could add a second cafeteria... but... the better option is to extend the weighing... to a full four weeks. Interviews... leave them until later"
24	C		"we expected vegetables to be the biggest item... No surprise there. What we didn't expect... More than half of it was food that was prepared in the kitchen but never served"
25	A		literature review: "I'd definitely make that section longer." "OK, we'll expand it."
26	C	not B	photographs: "Should we delete them?" "I wouldn't delete them. Put them at the end, in an appendix"
27	B		costs: "we should just take that section out... It's better to leave it out than to include figures you can't support."
28	E	not D	recommendations: "Should we rewrite them with you?" "I was going to suggest that... actually, no... They're fine as they are."
29	student union	students' union · Student Union	"Not from me, and not from the cafeteria manager: posters on campus have to be approved by the student union."
30	14 March	March 14 · 14th March · March 14th · 14 Mar · (14/3 or 3/14: accept, but advise writing the month in words) · not 10 March	"The original deadline was the tenth of March, but... I'll give you until the fourteenth."
Section 4 · Lecture on urban heat islands (note completion)			
31	rural		"noticeably warmer than the rural areas around it"

Q	ANSWER	ALSO ACCEPT / DON'T ACCEPT	SCRIPT LINE
32	night	not midday	"you might expect the difference to be greatest in the middle of the day... In fact, it's usually greatest at night."
33	asphalt	exact spelling only	"dark roofs and, above all, the asphalt we use on roads and parking lots"
34	vegetation	plants	"The second factor is the lack of vegetation. Plants release water through their leaves, and as that water evaporates, it cools the surrounding air."
35	vehicles	vehicle: no mark; cars: no mark (not what was said)	"Vehicles, factories and air conditioners all release waste heat into the street."
36	wind		"they also block the wind that would otherwise carry the warm air away"
37	electricity		"higher demand for electricity, as people turn up their air conditioning"
38	elderly	old / older: no mark (not what was said)	"the danger is greatest for elderly people, especially those who live alone"
39	white		"encourage building owners to paint their roofs white"
40	12	twelve · not 15	"up to twelve degrees Celsius cooler. You may see a figure of fifteen degrees quoted... so twelve is the more reliable figure."

PRACTICE TEST 1 · ACADEMIC READING KEY /40

Q	ANSWER	EVIDENCE IN THE PASSAGE (AND WHY NOT THE TRAP)
Passage 1 · "Pen, Keyboard and Memory"		
1	TRUE	"Typists almost always capture more words than people writing by hand" ("almost always" = "usually")
2	FALSE	"the two groups did equally well on questions about simple facts" (the handwriters did better only on explain/apply questions)
3	FALSE	"In Lindqvist's view, it is the summarizing, not the pen itself, that strengthens memory."
4	NOT GIVEN	Paragraph 4 describes Arriaga's instructions and results, but says nothing about where the study took place.
5	FALSE	"the gap between the two groups became smaller, though it did not disappear entirely"

Q	ANSWER	EVIDENCE IN THE PASSAGE (AND WHY NOT THE TRAP)
6	TRUE	"writing letters by hand, rather than selecting them on a keyboard, helps children to recognize those letters more quickly"
7	NOT GIVEN	"those who did so reported lower satisfaction with their courses": satisfaction, not grades. (A classic "own knowledge" trap.)
8	temptation	"a laptop offers constant temptation"
9	satisfaction	"reported lower satisfaction with their courses"
10	margins	"a bored student with a notebook can simply doodle in the margins" (margin: no mark)
11	disabilities	"For students with certain disabilities, meanwhile, the keyboard is not a convenience but a necessity."
12	engagement	"The key appears to be active engagement with the material"
13	reviewed	"notes are only valuable if they are reviewed" (review: no mark; the grammar of the summary needs the past participle)

Passage 2 • "Farming Upward"

14	iii	A describes the method (stacked trays, LEDs, no soil) and "the biggest change in food production since... the tractor"
15	vi	B: "The appeal of the idea is easy to understand. Because the crops are grown indoors..." (no pests, planned harvests, recycled water, freshness)
16	v	C: "The greatest obstacle is energy... This makes the business unusually sensitive to changes in the price of electricity."
17	i	D: "There is also the question of what can be grown... Staple crops such as wheat and rice are a different matter."
18	vii	E: "the environmental case depends almost entirely on where the power comes from"
19	ii	F: "These units rarely make money in a narrow financial sense, but... they have other kinds of value." (iv and viii are unused: land prices and governments are never discussed.)
20	D	"wheat grown indoors would currently cost many times more to produce than wheat grown in fields"
21	F	"hospital staff say that patients enjoy seeing food growing nearby"
22	C	"a number of well-funded vertical-farming companies were forced to cut production, and some closed altogether"

Q	ANSWER	EVIDENCE IN THE PASSAGE (AND WHY NOT THE TRAP)
23	A	"There is no soil. Instead, the roots hang in a thin, slowly moving film of water that carries a carefully measured mixture of nutrients"
24	LEDs	"lit by rows of pink-purple LEDs" · also accept pink-purple LEDs (a hyphenated word counts as one) · LED (singular): no mark
25	data centers	"built beside factories and data centers so that they can use the waste heat those buildings produce" · also accept data centres
26	parking lots	"empty stores and unused parking lots have been turned into small farms" · also accept unused parking lots (3 words)

Passage 3 · "The Uses of Boredom"

27	YES	"it is now possible to fill every spare moment... in escaping boredom so efficiently..."
28	YES	"I find this result intriguing, but I think it has been overstated."
29	NOT GIVEN	The writer criticizes how far the result is taken and notes "mixed results" when it was repeated, but never says whether it should have been published.
30	NO	"Telling a person in this situation to 'embrace boredom' would be unhelpful and possibly unkind."
31	NO	"Should we, then, try to be bored more often? I would not go that far."
32	B	"More recent work, however, treats boredom as a signal generated by the mind itself." (A = the older view; C twists the hunger comparison; D: "boredom is not a failure")
33	C	"The bored group produced more ideas, and their ideas were judged to be more original." (B: the task was about plastic cups)
34	B	"these reports come mostly from teachers and have not yet been studied systematically" (A: students complain only at first; C: teachers, not students)
35	C	Castillo: "boredom seems to help only when people cannot immediately escape from it"
36	D	Kim: "teenagers who reach for their phones as soon as they feel bored report being bored more often, not less"
37	A	Okafor: "an alarm that tells us our current activity is not using our abilities... comparable in some ways to hunger" (Brenner, B, is not used.)
38	fruit	"in the same way that a diet high in sugar makes fruit taste less sweet"
39	months	"Chronic boredom, the kind that persists for weeks or months"
40	surroundings	"Some people use such moments to plan, to reflect or simply to notice their surroundings."

◆ PRACTICE TEST 1 • QUESTION-TYPE MAP (FOR THE ERROR TALLY)

LISTENING	TYPE	READING	TYPE
1–6	form completion (names, spelling, numbers)	1–7	True / False / Not Given
7–10	table completion	8–13	summary completion (words from the passage)
11–15	map labelling	14–19	matching headings
16–18	multiple choice	20–23	matching information (which paragraph)
19–20	choose two	24–26	short answer
21–24	multiple choice (discussion)	27–31	Yes / No / Not Given
25–28	matching (decisions)	32–34	multiple choice
29–30	note completion	35–37	matching features (people)
31–40	note completion (lecture)	38–40	sentence completion

RAW SCORE → BAND CONVERSION

Approximate, based on publicly reported conversion ranges. The official conversion is not published as a single fixed table and varies slightly from one test version to another, so treat every result as a range of about ± 0.5 . Use these tables for full 40-question tests only (Practice Tests 1 and 2); for the diagnostic, use the cautious table in [diagnostic.html](#). They are consistent with the rough guide in online Lesson 1.1 (about 30/40 $\approx$ band 7, about 23/40 $\approx$ band 6).

◆ LISTENING / 40

RAW SCORE	APPROX. BAND
39–40	9.0
37–38	8.5
35–36	8.0
32–34	7.5
30–31	7.0
26–29	6.5
23–25	6.0
18–22	5.5

◆ ACADEMIC READING / 40

RAW SCORE	APPROX. BAND
39–40	9.0
37–38	8.5
35–36	8.0
33–34	7.5
30–32	7.0
27–29	6.5
23–26	6.0
19–22	5.5

RAW SCORE	APPROX. BAND
16–17	5.0
13–15	4.5
10–12	4.0
below 10	below 4.0

RAW SCORE	APPROX. BAND
15–18	5.0
13–14	4.5
10–12	4.0
below 10	below 4.0

Two cautions to share with learners. ① These papers were written for this class, not by the test makers, and are read aloud by a teacher rather than recorded, so a practice score is an *indication*, not a prediction. ② The General Training Reading test uses a different (stricter) conversion; this course and these tables are for **Academic** Reading only.

WRITING CRITERIA · BANDS 5–8

Paraphrased from the public IELTS band descriptors, in plain teacher language. For the official wording, see the descriptors published by the test owners.

Writing is marked on four criteria of equal weight. Give a band for each, then average them. **Task 2 counts twice as much as Task 1** in the Writing band, so in Class 16 estimate each task separately and weight Task 2 double. Each band below includes what is described in the band beneath it.

CRITERION	BAND 5	BAND 6	BAND 7	BAND 8
Task Response (Task 2) · Task Achievement (Task 1)	Answers only part of the question, or drifts into a related topic. The writer's view is hard to find or changes. Few ideas are explained; some are repeated or off the point. A response that is well under length is usually here. <i>Task 1:</i> details are reported mechanically, there is no clear overview, and some key figures are missing or misread.	Touches every part of the question, but some parts get much less attention. There is a position, though it may wobble or only become clear in the conclusion. Ideas are relevant, but some are listed rather than explained. <i>Task 1:</i> an overview is attempted; the main features are covered, though some detail is irrelevant or inaccurate.	Every part of the question is answered, and the writer's view is easy to follow from start to finish. Main points are explained and backed up; the usual weakness is a claim that is too broad or an example that loses focus. <i>Task 1:</i> a clear overview of the main trends or differences, with the key features selected and illustrated.	Every part is answered thoroughly. The position is clear and persuasive, and ideas are relevant, well explained and well supported, with only small, occasional lapses. <i>Task 1:</i> all key features are selected, compared and presented clearly and accurately.

CRITERION	BAND 5	BAND 6	BAND 7	BAND 8
Coherence & Cohesion	Some organization, but the argument jumps around. Linking words are few, wrong, or used in every sentence. Paragraphs are missing or confusing, and ideas are repeated because referencing is weak.	The argument can be followed and is generally organized. Linkers are used, but often mechanically ("Firstly... Moreover... Furthermore...") or occasionally wrongly. Referencing is sometimes unclear. Paragraphs exist but are not always logical.	Ideas are in a logical order and the argument moves forward. A range of linking words and referencing (<i>this trend, these measures, the former</i>) is used suitably, with a few slips or some overuse. Each paragraph has one clear central point.	The reader never has to work to follow the argument. Linking is natural and almost unnoticeable, referencing is smooth, and paragraphs are well judged.
Lexical Resource	A narrow range of words, just enough for the task, often repeated. Spelling and word-form errors are noticeable and sometimes make the reader stop and think.	Enough vocabulary for the task. Tries some less everyday words, not always accurately. Some spelling and word-form errors, but the meaning stays clear.	A flexible, fairly precise range, including some less common words and good collocations (<i>a substantial increase, pose a risk</i>) with a sense of style. Occasional mistakes in word choice, word form or spelling.	A wide range used easily and precisely, with natural collocation and uncommon words that fit. Only occasional slips.
Grammatical Range & Accuracy	A limited range of structures. Complex sentences are attempted but are usually less accurate than simple ones. Errors are frequent, and some cause difficulty. Punctuation is often faulty.	A mix of simple and complex sentences. There are errors in grammar and punctuation, but they rarely make the meaning unclear.	A variety of complex structures. Many sentences are completely correct. Grammar and punctuation are well controlled, with a few errors.	A wide range of structures. The great majority of sentences have no errors; mistakes are rare and random rather than repeated.

Things that pull any band down (Lesson 3.3): being under length (150 words for Task 1, 250 for Task 2), writing about a different question, no paragraphs, memorized "template" sentences that don't fit, and copying the question word for word (copied words aren't counted). In Task 2, a clear position in the introduction is the single fastest Task Response gain.

SPEAKING CRITERIA · BANDS 5–8

Paraphrased from the public IELTS band descriptors, in plain teacher language. For the official wording, see the descriptors published by the test owners.

Speaking is marked on four criteria of equal weight across the whole interview. **Accent is not a criterion:** learners are marked on how easy they are to understand and on their use of stress, rhythm and intonation (Lesson 4.2).

Personal content is never marked: invented answers score the same as true ones.

CRITERION	BAND 5	BAND 6	BAND 7	BAND 8
Fluency & Coherence	Keeps going, but speech slows, restarts or repeats often, especially on harder topics. Relies on a handful of connectors (<i>and, but, because</i>) and overuses them.	Wants to develop answers and can talk at length, but loses the thread at times through repetition, restarting or hesitation. Uses a range of connectors, not always suitably.	Talks at length comfortably and stays on track. There may be some pausing or self-correction, but the listener never loses the thread. Uses a good variety of connecting words and discourse markers (<i>the thing is, on top of that, that said</i>).	Talks at length with ease; pauses are for thinking about ideas, not searching for words. Develops answers fully and sensibly, and rarely repeats or corrects.
Lexical Resource	Can talk about familiar topics, but word choice is narrow and repetitive (<i>good, nice, a lot</i>). Tries to rephrase when a word is missing, with mixed success.	Enough vocabulary to discuss topics at length and be understood, even when some word choices don't quite fit. Usually manages to rephrase around a gap.	Talks flexibly about a range of topics. Uses some idiomatic and less everyday language with a feel for style and collocation, though not always correctly. Rephrases well.	A wide, precise vocabulary used with ease, including idiomatic phrases that sound natural. Only small slips. Rephrases smoothly whenever needed.
Grammatical Range & Accuracy	Simple sentences are mostly correct. Complex sentences are few and usually contain errors, some of which may confuse the listener.	Mixes simple and complex sentences. Complex ones often contain mistakes, but the meaning nearly always comes through.	Uses a range of complex sentences with some flexibility. Many sentences are completely correct, though some mistakes remain.	Uses a wide variety of structures flexibly. The great majority of sentences have no mistakes; errors are occasional and random.

CRITERION	BAND 5	BAND 6	BAND 7	BAND 8
Pronunciation	Mostly understandable, but some mispronounced words or sounds, or a flat, word-by-word delivery, make the listener work hard at times.	Generally understood throughout. Uses some features (stress, linking, intonation) effectively but not consistently; a few words or sounds cause brief difficulty.	Easy to understand. Good control of most features, such as word and sentence stress, chunking and intonation, with occasional lapses.	Easy to follow from start to finish. Uses stress, rhythm and intonation well to carry meaning; the accent makes little difference to understanding.

BAND-ESTIMATION WORKSHEET · ONE PER LEARNER

Learner: _____ Test: ☐ Diagnostic ☐ Practice Test 1 ☐ Practice Test 2 Date: _____

SKILL	RAW SCORE / CRITERION BANDS	BAND	TARGET	GAP
Listening	___ / 40 (diagnostic: ___ / 10)			
Reading	___ / 40 (diagnostic: ___ / 13)			
Writing	Task 1: TA ___ CC ___ LR ___ GRA ___ → ___ Task 2: TR ___ CC ___ LR ___ GRA ___ → ___ Writing $\approx$ (Task 1 + 2 × Task 2) ÷ 3 = ___			
Speaking	FC ___ LR ___ GRA ___ P ___ → average ___			
Overall	(L + R + W + S) ÷ 4 = _____ → rounded _____			

◆ ROUNDING

- ◆ **Overall band** (the test's rule, Lesson 1.1): average the four skills, then round to the nearest half band. An average ending in .25 goes **up** to .5; one ending in .75 goes **up** to the next whole band. Example: $7.0 + 6.5 + 6.0 + 6.0 = 25.5 \rightarrow 6.375 \rightarrow 6.5$.
- ◆ **Writing and Speaking criteria** (this kit's convention): average the four criteria and round **down** to the nearest half band. It keeps teacher estimates on the cautious side; examiners are trained, and we are estimating.

◆ WHAT GOES ON THE LEARNER'S COPY

- ◆ The bands, written as ranges ("Listening about 6.5")
- ◆ **One strength** in their own words ("You caught every correction in Section 1")
- ◆ **One priority**, with the cause code and the online lesson that trains it
- ◆ Nothing that compares them with other learners

RETURNING RESULTS KINDLY

For many learners, an IELTS score feels tied to their future: a course, a job, a family plan. A number handed back carelessly can undo weeks of confidence. The aim of feedback here is to keep every learner working, with a clear next step.

◆ PRINCIPLES

- ◆ **Private, never public.** No rankings, no "highest score," no reading bands aloud. Hand results back folded or in an envelope.
- ◆ **Process before number.** Start with what went well and what caused the lost marks; give the band last.
- ◆ **Ranges, not verdicts.** "About 6.0, and this test is only an indication." Never "You'll fail" or "You're not ready."
- ◆ **Name what is fixable.** Many lost marks come from technique (distractors, word limits, spelling, time), which can change in weeks.
- ◆ **Be honest about time.** Half a band in eight weeks is a common, good result. A bigger jump is possible but not guaranteed, and language growth takes longer than strategy.

◆ THINGS YOU CAN SAY

SAY: *Seven of your Listening mistakes were spelling or plurals. That's the easiest kind of mark to win back: it's a checking habit, not your English.*

SAY: *Your score went down from the diagnostic, and that's normal: this was a full test, with the hard sections. Let's compare like with like at Practice Test 2.*

SAY: *You need 7.0 and you're at about 6.0 today. That's a real gap, so let's plan it honestly: this course builds the technique, and you might want a few more weeks before you book.*

SAY: *You rated Reading "very hard," but you scored 29. Your English is ahead of your confidence.*

WHEN A RESULT HITS HARD

Some learners will be upset, particularly if a visa, a job or a registration deadline depends on the score. Give them time and privacy; offer a short conversation after class rather than discussing it in front of others. Don't make promises about the real test, and don't give advice on immigration or admissions rules: point them to the institution or test center for official requirements, and keep the conversation on what *this course* can do in the weeks you have. If a learner mentions serious distress, follow your organization's support and referral procedures.

FROM ERRORS TO A STUDY PLAN

In Class 9, each learner writes a cause code next to every wrong answer (the codes are on the teacher pages of Practice Test 1), counts them, and picks the **top one or two**. The table turns each code into a concrete fix and the

online lesson that trains it (https://rays-esl.netlify.app/curriculum-ielts/lesson_NN.html). One well-chosen focus beats a long list.

CODE	WHAT HAPPENED	THE FIX (A HABIT TO PRACTICE)	LESSON
D	Distractor (Listening): wrote the first detail the speaker said, not the correction (L3, L5, L12, L40...)	Listen for <i>actually, sorry, no, it's..., it used to be... but</i> ; hold the pen until the speaker moves on. Drill: the "take the final version" exercises.	2.1 · lesson_04
S	Spelling or plural (Listening: heard it but misspelled it or missed a plural, <i>spray/ sprays</i>) · copied a word wrongly (Reading)	A 2-minute spelling-and-plural check at the end of every section; a personal list of words misspelled in practice; dictation of names and numbers in pairs. In Reading, copy letter by letter from the passage.	L: 2.1 · lesson_04 R: 2.2 · lesson_05
W	Word limit / wrong form : broke the limit ("the aging equipment" for two words) or wrote the wrong word form	Circle the limit in every instruction before starting; cross out articles and repeated question words; remember a hyphenated word counts as one; check the answer fits the gap grammatically.	L: 2.1 · lesson_04 R: 2.2 · lesson_05
N	Number, letter or date misheard (Listening): 13/30, 14th/15th, a letter in a spelled name	Pair dictation of numbers, dates and spelled names; say the stress aloud (thirTEEN / THIRty); write numbers as digits.	2.1 · lesson_04
L	Lost my place / froze (Listening) and missed several answers in a row	Read ahead in every pause; underline the keyword in the <i>next two</i> questions; if you miss one, jump to the next immediately.	2.1 · lesson_04
P	Missed the paraphrase : didn't recognize it; looked or listened for the exact question words	Keyword-and-synonym mapping; underline the keyword, write two likely synonyms, then scan or listen. Build topic word banks.	1.2 · lesson_02 + L: 2.1 · lesson_04 + R: 2.2 · lesson_05
M	Word-match trap (Reading): chose an option because it used the same words as the text, with a different meaning	Treat an exact word match as a warning, not proof; read the whole sentence around it and check the meaning matches the question.	2.2 · lesson_05
O	Looked in the wrong place (Reading)	Use passage order for order-following types; locate with a scan word (name, number, capital) before reading closely.	2.2 · lesson_05
T	Ran out of time / left a blank (Reading, usually on Passage 3)	Cap each passage at 20 minutes; do order-following types first and matching information last; guess and move on; never leave a blank.	2.2 · 4.3 · lesson_05, lesson_12

CODE	WHAT HAPPENED	THE FIX (A HABIT TO PRACTICE)	LESSON
F	Confused False and Not Given: chose False when the text was silent, or Not Given when it clearly contradicted	Ask "Can I point to words that clash?" If yes, False; if not, Not Given. Justify every answer in one sentence during practice.	2.3 · lesson_06
K	Used own knowledge, not the text	Ask "Where does the <i>text</i> say this?" If you can't point to it, it's Not Given, however true it is in real life.	2.3 · lesson_06
Q	Missed a qualifier (<i>all, some, only, always, the most...</i>)	Circle every qualifier in the statement and find its partner in the text; <i>some</i> ≠ <i>most</i> , <i>often</i> ≠ <i>always</i> .	2.3 · lesson_06
H	Heading matched a detail , not the main idea	Name each paragraph's main idea in five words <i>before</i> reading the headings; test the heading against the whole paragraph.	2.3 · lesson_06
X	Transfer error (both sections): right answer, but in the wrong box or illegible	Transfer in blocks of five and check the question number each time; write in capitals; in Reading, leave time to transfer (there is no extra transfer time).	4.3 · lesson_12

◆ WRITING AND SPEAKING (FROM THE DIAGNOSTIC)

- ◆ **No clear position / only part answered** → the 5-minute plan and question-type analysis, Lesson 3.2 (lesson_08)
- ◆ **Mechanical linking, no paragraphs** → referencing and the over-linking trap, Lesson 3.3 (lesson_09)
- ◆ **Repeated grammar errors** (articles, tense, agreement) → "errors that cap your band" and a personal error list, Lesson 1.3 (lesson_03)
- ◆ **One-sentence answers in Speaking** → answer + why + example, Lesson 4.1 (lesson_10)
- ◆ **Basic, repeated vocabulary; flat delivery** → upgrades, collocation, stress and intonation, Lesson 4.2 (lesson_11)

◆ A PLAN THE LEARNER WRITES (CLASS 9)

My top code: _____ My second code: _____

The habit I'll practice: _____

When (two times a week, 20–30 minutes):

How I'll know it's working: fewer _____ errors in my next timed section

Revisit it at Practice Test 2: learners compare their code counts, not just their bands. A drop in their top code is progress worth celebrating, even when the band hasn't moved yet.

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